

INDIAN HISTORY

Ancient, Medieval & Modern India

For SSC | UPSC | Railway | Banking | State PSC | Defence Exams

ANCIENT INDIA - 1. INDUS VALLEY CIVILIZATION (3300-1300 BCE)

- > Also called Harappan Civilization (first discovered site: Harappa, 1921 by Daya Ram Sahni).
- > Mohenjo-daro: Discovered 1922 by R.D. Banerjee. 'Mound of the Dead'. Great Bath, Granary.
- > Bronze Age civilization. Urban planning: Grid pattern roads, drainage system, brick houses.
- > Major sites: Harappa (Pakistan), Mohenjo-daro (Pakistan), Lothal (Gujarat - dockyard), Kalibangan (Rajasthan - ploughed field), Dholavira (Gujarat - water harvesting), Rakhigarhi (Haryana - largest Indian site).
- > Economy: Agriculture (wheat, barley), trade, crafts. No iron. Used copper and bronze.
- > Religion: Mother Goddess, Pashupati (proto-Shiva), tree worship, no temples found.
- > Script: Undeciphered. Written right to left. About 400 signs.
- > Decline: Possibly floods, drought, invasion, or tectonic activity.

ANCIENT INDIA - 2. VEDIC PERIOD (1500-600 BCE)

- > Rig Vedic Period (1500-1000 BCE): Aryans settled in Sapta Sindhu (Punjab). Pastoral society.
- > Rig Veda: Oldest text. 10 Mandalas, 1028 Hymns. Gayatri Mantra in 3rd Mandala.
- > Later Vedic Period (1000-600 BCE): Moved to Ganga-Yamuna plains. Agriculture dominant.
- > Four Vedas: Rig (hymns), Sama (music/chanting), Yajur (rituals), Atharva (magic/medicine).
- > Upanishads: Philosophical texts. 'Satyameva Jayate' from Mundaka Upanishad.
- > Varna System: Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, Shudras (became rigid later).
- > Society: Patriarchal. Joint family. Women had some rights in early period (declined later).

ANCIENT INDIA - 3. BUDDHISM & JAINISM

Buddhism:

- > Founder: Siddhartha Gautama (563-483 BCE). Born: Lumbini (Nepal). Clan: Shakya.
- > Enlightenment: Bodhi Gaya (under Peepal/Bodhi tree). First Sermon: Sarnath (Dharmachakra Pravartana).
- > Death (Mahaparinirvana): Kushinagar (UP). Four Noble Truths + Eightfold Path (Middle Way).
- > Three Jewels (Triratna): Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha.
- > Buddhist Councils: 1st (Rajgriha, Ajatashatru), 2nd (Vaishali), 3rd (Pataliputra, Ashoka), 4th (Kashmir, Kanishka).
- > Two sects: Hinayana (individual salvation) and Mahayana (universal salvation, idol worship).

Jainism:

- > 24 Tirthankaras. 1st: Rishabhadeva. 23rd: Parshvanath. 24th: Vardhamana Mahavira.
- > Mahavira (540-468 BCE): Born Kundagrama (Bihar). Kshatriya prince. Attained Kaivalya (enlightenment).
- > Five vows: Ahimsa (non-violence), Satya (truth), Asteya (non-stealing), Aparigraha (non-possession), Brahmacharya (celibacy).
- > Three jewels (Triratna): Right Faith, Right Knowledge, Right Conduct.
- > Two sects: Digambara (sky-clad) and Shvetambara (white-clad).

ANCIENT INDIA - 4. MAURYA EMPIRE (322-185 BCE)

- > Founded by Chandragupta Maurya (322 BCE) with help of Chanakya/Kautilya.
- > Chanakya wrote Arthashastra (treatise on statecraft, economics, military strategy).
- > Chandragupta defeated Seleucus Nicator. Megasthenes (Greek ambassador) wrote 'Indica'.
- > Bindusara: Son of Chandragupta. Extended empire to Deccan. Called 'Amitraghata'.
- > Ashoka (268-232 BCE): Greatest Mauryan ruler. Kalinga War (261 BCE) - turned to Buddhism.
- > Ashoka's Edicts: Rock edicts, Pillar edicts. Spread Dhamma (morality). Lion Capital at Sarnath (national emblem).
- > Administration: Centralized. Provinces > Districts > Villages. Spy system. Mauryan army was largest.
- > Decline: Weak successors. Last ruler Brihadratha killed by Pushyamitra Shunga (185 BCE).

ANCIENT INDIA - 5. GUPTA EMPIRE (320-550 CE) - GOLDEN AGE

- > Founded by Sri Gupta. Greatest rulers: Chandragupta I, Samudragupta, Chandragupta II (Vikramaditya).
- > Samudragupta: 'Napoleon of India' (by V.A. Smith). Allahabad Pillar inscription describes conquests.
- > Chandragupta II (Vikramaditya): Defeated Shakas. Nine Gems (Navaratnas) in court including Kalidasa.
- > Golden Age of India: Science, art, literature, astronomy flourished.
- > Aryabhata: Mathematician/astronomer. Calculated Pi, Earth's rotation. Book: Aryabhatiya.
- > Kalidasa: Greatest Sanskrit poet. Works: Shakuntala, Meghaduta, Raghuvamsha.
- > Fa-Hien: Chinese traveler visited during Chandragupta II's reign.
- > Nalanda University: Established during Gupta period. Became world's first residential university.
- > Iron Pillar of Delhi: Rustless iron from Gupta period - metallurgical marvel.
- > Decimal system, concept of zero attributed to this period (Aryabhata/Brahmagupta).

MEDIEVAL INDIA - KEY DYNASTIES & SULTANATE

- > Delhi Sultanate (1206-1526): 5 dynasties - Slave (Mamluk), Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi.
- > Qutub-ud-din Aibak (1206): First Sultan. Built Qutub Minar (completed by Iltutmish). Adhai Din Ka Jhopra.
- > Razia Sultan (1236-40): First and only woman ruler of Delhi Sultanate.
- > Alauddin Khalji (1296-1316): Market reforms. Conquered most of India. Repelled Mongol invasions.
- > Muhammad bin Tughlaq (1325-51): Shifted capital Delhi to Daulatabad. Introduced token currency. 'Man of ideas'.
- > Firoz Shah Tughlaq: Irrigation canals, hospitals, schools. Imposed Jizya on Brahmins.
- > Vijayanagara Empire (1336-1646): Founded by Harihara & Bukka (Sangama dynasty). Capital: Hampi. Krishna Deva Raya (greatest ruler).
- > Bahmani Kingdom (1347-1518): Deccan. Split into 5 Sultanates (Bijapur, Golconda, Ahmednagar, Bidar, Berar).

MEDIEVAL INDIA - MUGHAL EMPIRE (1526-1857)

- > Babur (1526-30): First Mughal. Won Battle of Panipat (1526) against Ibrahim Lodi. Used gunpowder + cannons.
- > Humayun (1530-56): Lost to Sher Shah Suri. Regained power later. Died falling from library stairs.
- > Akbar (1556-1605): Greatest Mughal. Won 2nd Battle of Panipat (1556). Mansabdari system. Din-i-Ilahi. Sulh-i-Kul (universal peace). Navratnas. Revenue system by Todar Mal. Abolished Jizya.
- > Jahangir (1605-27): Justice chain. Patron of painting. Nur Jahan (powerful queen). Sir Thomas Roe visited.
- > Shah Jahan (1627-58): Built Taj Mahal, Red Fort, Jama Masjid. 'Golden Age of Mughal architecture'.
- > Aurangzeb (1658-1707): Last great Mughal. Expanded empire to maximum. Reimposed Jizya. Strict orthodox rule. Deccan wars weakened empire.
- > Later Mughals (1707-1857): Weak rulers. Bahadur Shah II - last Mughal (exiled after 1857 revolt).

MODERN INDIA - BRITISH PERIOD & FREEDOM STRUGGLE

- > East India Company: Came for trade (1600). Battle of Plassey (1757, Robert Clive) began political control.
- > Battle of Buxar (1764): Established British supremacy in Bengal. Diwani rights obtained.
- > 1857 Revolt: First War of Independence. Started at Meerut (Mangal Pandey at Barrackpore). Leaders: Rani Laxmibai, Tantia Tope, Nana Sahib, Bahadur Shah Zafar.
- > Indian National Congress (1885): Founded by A.O. Hume. First President: W.C. Bonnerjee. First session: Bombay.
- > Moderate Phase (1885-1905): Dadabhai Naoroji, Gokhale, Pherozeshah Mehta. Constitutional methods, petitions.
- > Extremist Phase (1905-19): Bal Gangadhar Tilak ('Swaraj is my birthright'), Lala Lajpat Rai, Bipin Chandra Pal.
- > Partition of Bengal (1905): By Lord Curzon. Led to Swadeshi Movement. Revoked 1911.
- > Jallianwala Bagh Massacre (April 13, 1919): General Dyer fired on peaceful crowd in Amritsar. ~400 killed.
- > Non-Cooperation Movement (1920-22): Led by Gandhi. Khilafat alliance. Withdrew after Chauri Chaura.
- > Civil Disobedience Movement (1930): Dandi March (Salt Satyagraha, March 12-April 6). Gandhi-Irwin Pact 1931.
- > Quit India Movement (Aug 8, 1942): 'Do or Die'. All leaders arrested. Parallel governments formed.
- > INA & Subhash Chandra Bose: 'Give me blood, I'll give you freedom'. Azad Hind Fauj.
- > Independence: August 15, 1947. Partition into India and Pakistan. Lord Mountbatten - last Viceroy.

MODERN INDIA - KEY ACTS & MOVEMENTS (TIMELINE)

Year	Event
1757	Battle of Plassey - British control over Bengal begins
1857	First War of Independence (Sepoy Mutiny)
1885	Indian National Congress founded
1905	Partition of Bengal / Swadeshi Movement
1906	Muslim League founded (Dhaka)
1909	Morley-Minto Reforms (separate electorate for Muslims)
1919	Rowlatt Act / Jallianwala Bagh / Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms
1920	Non-Cooperation Movement / Khilafat Movement
1928	Simon Commission ('Go Back Simon')
1929	Lahore Congress - Purna Swaraj resolution (Jan 26, 1930)
1930	Civil Disobedience / Dandi March / 1st Round Table Conference
1931	Gandhi-Irwin Pact / 2nd RTC / Bhagat Singh executed
1935	Government of India Act (provincial autonomy)
1942	Quit India Movement / Cripps Mission
1946	Cabinet Mission / Constituent Assembly formed / Direct Action Day
1947	Indian Independence Act / Partition / Aug 15 Independence